ONE NATION, ONE POLL

PROMISES

- Reduces election expenses of political parties
- May improve administrative efficiency and governance and streamline the implementation of state and central policies
- Can enhance voter turnout as people go out to cast their ballot simultaneously

PITFALLS

- Fails to guarantee political stability for parties and ensure that they complete their ongoing five-year tenures
- Centre can end up having the upper hand, with little or no space for states to express dissent
- May overshadow local issues and threaten the influence of regional parties
- May put smaller players at a big disadvantage in terms of poll strategy and expenses as they try to compete with national parties

ity. What makes these concerns seem legitimate is the fact that only one Opposition leader, Congress's Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, was appointed to the Kovind committee, though he ultimately declined to be part of it, dismissing the exercise as an "eyewash" and claiming that the committee's "terms of reference" were such that they would only "guarantee its conclusions". Thus, the Kovind panel, as of now, is devoid of any non-BJP political leader, except Ghulam Nabi Azad, who quit the Congress last year to form his own regional party in Jammu and Kashmir.

Non-Congress Opposition parties, too, have vehemently opposed the ONOP idea. "One Nation, One Poll is an attempt to undermine federalism," Tamil Nadu chief minister and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) supremo M.K. Stalin said on social media on September 3, wondering why his party, the third-largest in the Lok Sabha, does not find representation on the Kovind panel. The same day, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge was on X (formerly Twitter), saying, "This idea has been extensively examined and rejected by three committees in the past. It remains to be seen whether the fourth one has been constituted with a pre-decided outcome in mind. It baffles us that a representative from the prestigious Election Commission of India has been excluded from the committee."

Whatever be the government's intention, what's indisputable is that ONOP cannot be implemented overnight with just parliamentary legislation. It will require extensive changes in the Constitution, some of which will have to be approved by the majority of the state legislatures for the new law to come into force. These entail changes to Article 83 (duration of both houses of Parliament), Article 85 (relating to sessions of Parliament, its prorogation and dissolution), Article 172 (duration of state legislatures), Article 174 (relating to the dissolution of the state legislatures) and Article 356 (about the imposition of President's rule). Currently, the BJP is in power either on its own or as part of ruling coalitions in almost half of India's states. While that may hold the party in good stead to some extent, navigating legal challenges on constitutional issues won't be that simple.

There are other implications too. The ONOP system, if implemented immediately, will defer assembly polls for Mizoram, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Telangana—all due later this year—to 2024. Elections for these states may then be held along with polls in Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Arunachal Pradesh and Sikkim, around the same time as the Lok Sabha election. Such a situation naturally raises the question of whether this will mean the imposition of President's rule in some states, especially in the five that are to go to the polls before December-end this year. That will invariably weaken the ruling parties' grip on governance in their respective states.

OPPOSITION PARTIES ARE CONCERNED THAT THE 'ONE NATION, ONE POLL' IDEA, IF IMPLEMENTED, MAY HURT INDIA'S MULTI-PARTY SYSTEM AND USHER IN PRESIDENTIAL-STYLE ELECTIONS

The Modi government's ONOP push is not a bolt out of the blue, though. Ever since it assumed office in 2014, the BJP has been chasing that goal doggedly. In December 2015, a parliamentary standing committee had prepared a report that supported holding simultaneous polls to the Lok Sabha and state assemblies. Two years later, Bibek Debroy and Kishore Desai